If even just a few of the world's dictators choose to put their trust in AI, this could have far-reaching consequences for the whole of humanity. Science fiction is full of scenarios of an AI getting out of control and enslaving or eliminating humankind. Most sci-fi plots explore these scenarios in the context of democratic capitalist societies. This is understandable. Authors living in democracies are obviously interested in their own societies, whereas authors living in dictatorships are usually discouraged from criticising their rulers. But the weakest spot in humanity's anti-AI shield is probably the dictators. The easiest way for an AI to seize power is not by breaking out of Dr Frankenstein's lab but by ingratiating itself with some paranoid Tiberius.

This is not a prophecy, just a possibility. After 1945, dictators and their subordinates cooperated with democratic governments and their citizens to contain nuclear weapons. On 9 July 1955, Albert Einstein, Bertrand Russell and a number of other eminent scientists and thinkers published the Russell–Einstein Manifesto, calling on the leaders of both democracies and dictatorships to cooperate on preventing nuclear war. 'We appeal,' said the manifesto, 'as human beings, to human beings: remember your humanity, and forget the rest. If you can do so, the way lies open to a new Paradise; if you cannot, there lies before you the risk of universal death.'[15] This is true of AI too. It would be foolish of dictators to believe that AI will necessarily tilt the balance of power in their favour. If they aren't careful, AI will just grab power to itself.